

Quantificational controls: attestations and provenance

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I SCOPE AND COMPARISON

This supplement records the independent quantificational uses discussed in §2.5 of *Determinatives as nouns in English*. It preserves the comparison table, retained attestations, and source-verification limits, together with further corpus records used elsewhere in the article. The searches establish selected occurrences, without estimating their frequency or establishing an ordering of the constructions.

The Cambridge grammar of the English language (CGEL; Huddleston and Pullum, 2002) includes *several* among determinatives and treats quantificational *certain* and *various* as marginal members. The *of*-phrase with independent *certain* and *various* is hardly omissible. The partitive with *certain* is relatively formal; that with *various* is accepted by some speakers, primarily in American English (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 392–393, 411–413).

Table 1 separates NP dependents from the surrounding construction. The argument frames are *X of them*, *X who arrived left*, and anaphoric *X left*. The existential frames are *There are X of them*, *There are X who can help*, and anaphoric *Are there X?* Interpret the constructed comparisons with people under discussion. Argument use also includes complementation of prepositions. The common-noun controls retain *a* in *a lot*.

Table 1: Independent quantificational uses. G: described in CGEL; R: restricted there; I: constructed positive illustration in the stated frame. Numbered references identify attestations below. S: searched, with no qualifying attestation retained; this isn't an ungrammaticality judgment.

Expression	Argument use			Existential displaced subject		
	Partitive PP	Relative clause	No dependent	Partitive PP	Relative clause	No dependent
<i>many</i>	G	G	G	<i>I</i>	<i>I</i>	<i>I</i>
<i>several</i>	G	<i>I</i>	G	<i>I</i>	<i>I</i>	<i>I</i>
<i>certain</i>	G	S	R	(4a)	(3g)	S
<i>various</i>	G	(2a)	R	(4b)	S	S
<i>numerous</i>	(1b)	(2b)	(1d)	(4c)	(3f)	(4d)
<i>multiple</i>	(1c)	(2c)	(1e)	(3b)	(3d)	(3a)
<i>countless</i>	(1a)	(2d)	(2e)	(3c)	(3e)	(4e)
<i>plenty</i>	G	<i>I</i>	<i>I</i>	<i>I</i>	<i>I</i>	<i>I</i>
<i>a lot</i>	G	<i>I</i>	<i>I</i>	<i>I</i>	<i>I</i>	<i>I</i>

The G and R cells retain the qualifications just stated; the common-noun partitives follow *CGEL* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 349–350). The relative use of *many* follows *CGEL*’s discussion of the human interpretation (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 414). The attestations below combine targeted searches in NOW and COCA with separately located examples. Expanded contexts exclude overt following nouns, predicative inversions, and mathematical *multiple*. These searches establish selected occurrences; they supply no usage rates.¹

The examples in (1) show partitive and independent subject uses of further quantity words. The *countless* partitive comes from academic prose; the *multiple* partitive from a blog discussion. The final two examples have independent quantifiers as subjects, with people recoverable from context. Their occurrence requires a description even where speakers differ over their acceptability.

- (1) a. *countless of their particular statements and deeds*²
- b. *numerous of its inhabitants*³
- c. *multiple of the fast casual eateries*⁴
- d. *numerous were injured*⁵
- e. *multiple were injured*⁶

Relative postmodification extends the comparison in (2). The first four quantity words complement prepositions and have relative postmodifiers. The final *countless* is a subject without a dependent, with viewers supplied by the preceding clause.

- (2) a. *think about various who had done it and who hadn’t*⁷
- b. *he has heard from numerous who are “deeply concerned”*⁸
- c. *according to multiple who have spoken to him*⁹
- d. *paving the way for countless who followed him*¹⁰

¹ Searches conducted on 12–13 September 2026 in NOW and COCA, using surface strings without part-of-speech filters. Queries, retained excerpts, and verification limits are recorded in notes/2026-09-12-quantifier-controls-corpus.json; separate source checks are in notes/2026-09-12-quantifier-controls-sources.json. The fourteen-cell follow-up is recorded in notes/2026-09-13-quantifier-cells.json.

² Thomas Hughson, “Interpreting Vatican II: ‘A New Pentecost’”, *Theological Studies* 69 (2008), p. 9; COCA academic record, checked against the journal PDF. The NP is object of *irradiate*.

³ Norman Harrington, *New York Times*, 7 April 1968, as quoted in *Merriam-Webster’s Dictionary of English Usage* and reproduced in Reynolds and Pullum’s “New members of closed classes in English”, §2.1.2. Verified through that draft; the newspaper original wasn’t checked.

⁴ COCA, 2012 blog discussion under “BurgerFi Bringing Its Burgers to...”. The surrounding phrase is *in front of multiple of the fast casual eateries*. Expanded corpus context and source metadata checked; the original page wasn’t available.

⁵ Page Six, 4 July 2022; NOW expanded context. The clause follows a coordinated clause about people who died. Here *numerous* is the canonical subject.

⁶ Ivana Saric and Herb Scribner, *Axios*, 27 June 2022, opening sentence; original page checked.

⁷ Stephen Tompkinson, quoted by James Hibbs in *Radio Times*, 29 April 2026; NOW and original interview. The context concerns identifying killers in detective scripts; no audio check.

⁸ ABC News, 18 August 2020; NOW record dated 19 August and original article. The antecedent is Republican attorneys.

⁹ The London Free Press, NOW record dated 19 November 2018, on recruiting campaign staff; concordance and source metadata checked. The original page wasn’t available.

¹⁰ WFTV, NOW record dated 7 January 2022, on Sidney Poitier; concordance and source metadata checked. The original URL returned an error page.

- e. *countless were left in floods of tears*¹¹

Existentials show a further range in (3). In (3a), *multiple* ends the question, with wedding dresses under discussion. The next two examples contain partitives. The remaining examples have relative postmodifiers and include published prose, a hearing transcript, and reported speech. Source locations identify the records; they don't establish each speaker's or writer's variety.

- (3) a. *are there multiple?*¹²
 b. *there are multiple of them*¹³
 c. *There are countless of them out there*¹⁴
 d. *There are multiple that are cited in my response.*¹⁵
 e. *There are countless who have greatly impacted their communities*¹⁶
 f. *there are numerous who are willing to donate*¹⁷
 g. *there are certain who would not like ...*¹⁸

The additional existential examples in (4) supply partitives with *certain*, *various*, and *numerous*. The final two have no NP dependent: *numerous* refers to benefits of a college education and *countless* to investment options. These contexts establish anaphoric interpretations without an overt following nominal.

- (4) a. *There are certain of our friends.*¹⁹
 b. *There are various of Maro's own inventions*²⁰
 c. *There are numerous of them.*²¹
 d. *I'm aware there are numerous.*²²

¹¹John Murphy, *Extra.ie*, 17 April 2022; NOW and original article. The preceding clause mentions viewers of *DIY SOS*.

¹²Kira Bindrim, in a *Quartz podcast transcript*, 2022; NOW and original transcript. The preceding question introduces wedding dresses. NOW dates the record 22 February; the current page reports an update on 20 July.

¹³Ivan Mehta, *TechCrunch*, 16 September 2022; NOW and original article. The antecedent is objects in a photo.

¹⁴"Facebook's Future Is Brighter Than Ever", *Seeking Alpha*, 25 May 2020; NOW expanded context and source metadata. The antecedent is payment apps.

¹⁵Zachary Loyed, public-records hearing, *State of Florida v. Thomas Lee Gudinas*, 29 May 2025, transcript p. 7, lines 14–15; *Appendix C*, PDF p. 55. Original transcript checked; *multiple* refers to cases.

¹⁶"The Sisterhood List", *Metro*, 1 October 2023; NOW expanded context and source metadata.

¹⁷Nana Patekar, as quoted in English by IANS in *The Indian Express*, 19 September 2015; NOW and original article. The original language of the speech wasn't established.

¹⁸Donald Trump, as quoted in *Fox News*, 25 March 2020; NOW record dated 26 March and original article. The quotation was checked against the article, without an audio check.

¹⁹Sharad Pawar, quoted in English by Manish Tewari in *Deccan Chronicle*, 8 July 2018; NOW record dated 7 July and original article. The original speech language and audio weren't checked.

²⁰Erica Platter, *Daily Maverick*, 8 March 2019; NOW and original article. The context lists cakes, with supplementary examples following the partitive.

²¹Sunday Cyriacus Umeha, interviewed by Adamu Abuh in *The Guardian (Nigeria)*, 7 June 2025; NOW and original interview. The antecedent is people from Enugu appointed to government positions.

²²Danny Sapio, *The Next Web*, 15 December 2019; NOW record dated 29 December and original article, syndicated from uxdesign.cc.

e. *In fact, there are countless.*²³

No qualifying attestation was retained for four cells: argument *certain* with a relative, bare existential *certain*, and existential *various* with a relative or without a dependent. The bounded searches don't establish exclusion. These cells retain a different evidential status from the positive examples and from *CGEL*'s stated restrictions.

2 CHECKS OF STATED EXCLUSIONS

The article states several exclusions as starred examples. Each was checked against COCA on 17 September 2026 with the search strings in Table 2; the returned lines were screened by a typed-judgment model for the excluded structure and every line above the screen's floor was read. A zero or an unattested result is not an ungrammaticality judgment, and an attested structure is reported with its register. Two exclusions were restated in the article as a result; the lines, counts, and readings are preserved in the project repository under `corpus/exclusion_tests/`.

²³*Financial Post*, NOW record dated 3 August 2013; complete sentence and adjacent context checked in the concordance. The original page wasn't available.

Table 2: Corpus checks of exclusions stated in the article. Queries use English-Corpora.org syntax; [v*], [nn*], [nn2*], [j*] and [at*] are tag families, and / alternates single words. Hits are lines read unless marked List.

Exclusion	Query	Hits	Result; handling
Ordinary dependence of <i>every</i>	each/every [v*]; each/every was/has/ will (List); NOW: every was; every has	618 lines with <i>every</i> read (of 1,095 with <i>each</i> or <i>every</i>); List: <i>each</i> has/was/will 1,578/1,005/507 against <i>every</i> will/has/was 12/8/3; NOW: 164 saved lines (96 for <i>every was</i> , 68 for <i>every has</i>)	COCA includes ellipsis, reply fragments, and binomials; NOW has three anaphoric candidates in published prose, two confirmed on publication pages and one differing from the currently indexed source (<i>Each</i>); complete-absence claim withdrawn; fragment limited to the ordinary dependent pattern; productivity of the anaphoric use unsettled; totals are not rates
Singular agreement with <i>each of the people</i>	each of them was/ were/is/are/has/ have (List); each of the [nn2*] was/were	389 singular, 78 plural; 151 <i>was</i> , 73 <i>were</i>	plural verb forms in about a sixth of the specified query hits after <i>each of</i> <i>them</i> ; plural agreement attested in edited prose as well as speech; restated with the query proportion (article §2.1)
Attributive <i>*so numerous mistakes</i>	so numerous [nn*]; too numerous [nn*]	4 + 4	none for <i>so</i> ; three marginal web lines for <i>too</i> (<i>too numerous</i> <i>inaccuracies</i>); holds for <i>so</i>
Degree adverb on a non-gradable determinative (<i>*very every, *very some, *very this</i>)	very every/some/ this; so every/some/ this	7 <i>very</i> lines read; 22,938 (List) for <i>so</i> ; contexts not retained for review	no qualifying line among the <i>very</i> contexts; two jocular cases (<i>very</i> <i>this, very this year</i>); holds for <i>very</i>
Reversed order (<i>*very a few, *a quite few</i>)	very a few; a quite few	0	unattested; holds
Partitive <i>*no of the students</i>	no of the	0	unattested; holds
Compounds exclude an article and a pre-head adjective	[at*] [j*] someone/ somebody/something; [at*] someone/ somebody/something	496 + 494 lines; <i>special someone</i> 282, <i>certain</i> <i>someone</i> 120 (List)	attested at volume and productively (<i>an anonymous someone, a furry</i> <i>something, such an anyone</i>); restated as the set-denoting use (article §6.1)

3 FURTHER CORPUS RECORDS

The following records preserve the queries, additional attestations, and reading details behind the article's shortened corpus notes. They document selected results and retain the limits of each search or reading.

3.1 INDEPENDENT USES OF ⟨every⟩

COCA List counts (17 September 2026): *each has* 1,578, *each was* 1,005, *each will* 507, against *every will* 12, *every has* 8, *every was* 3. The saved material contains 618 COCA lines with *every* before a verb and 164 NOW lines for *every was* and *every has*. These are search totals, not matched opportunities for independent use or an estimate of its grammatical rate.

The NOW material contains three anaphoric candidates in published prose. “Every has a story” remains on the *Patch publication page* (30 July 2025), in a paragraph about the city’s parks. “Every has different blocking mechanics” remains on the *Guardian page* (9 February 2024). Both were checked on 19 September 2026. The occurrences disprove the earlier report of complete absence; their productivity and status in standard usage remain unsettled.

The third candidate, “Every has its strengths”, differs from the currently indexed *News24 article* (1 May 2020), which has *Each*. Direct opening was blocked, but search returned the article text. The source discrepancy is unresolved; the saved concordance is retained. The original screening outputs and the corrected reading are under corpus/exclusion_tests/.

The COCA reading also records ellipsis (“if not every, then almost every male head of household”, *Social History*, 1995), reply fragments, and binomials (“to be open and generous to all and every”, fiction, 2015). Those constructions don’t exhaust the saved NOW evidence. The article treats dependence as the ordinary pattern while acknowledging the anaphoric occurrences; the formal fragment represents that ordinary pattern.

3.2 PREDICATIVE QUANTITY EXPRESSIONS

The hand-supplied batches from 18 September 2026 include 81 COCA entries described as sentence-final *be much*: “It won’t be much” (*Denver Post*, 1997); “Pay won’t be much” (*Ruben’s Place*, 2012); “There hasn’t been much” (*CBS This Morning*, 2014). Two further searches were run on 19 September 2026 with their query strings recorded: [x*] [be] much . (30 texts) and [be] [x*] much . (198 texts), saved in full under corpus/independent_argument/. The second is the evidence that bare predicative *much* takes entity-denoting subjects under negation (“The town isn’t much”, *Lone Star*, 1996; “her resume wasn’t much”, *Town & Country*, 1998). Both queries require a negator, so neither bears on affirmative predicative *much*. Four of the 30 lines in the first are one line of *Romeo and Juliet* (“the hurt can not be much”), which the article cited until 19 September and no longer does. A NOW batch described as sentence-final *there is little* contains 23 entries: “industry sources say there is little” (Reuters, 2011); “past the 90-minute mark, there is little” (*Globe and Mail*, 2026). The exact query strings for these two batches weren’t recorded.

Two further COCA batches contain 45 entries with *became/become too much to* and 46 with forms of *seem* followed by *too/so much/little to*. Examples include “the pain and immobility became too much to bear” (Associated Press, 2007); “the burden of debt became too much to bear” (amazon.com, 2012); “sympathy seemed too much to hope for” (*Otherwise Engaged*, 2005); and “it seemed so little to give” (*Biting the Bullet*, 2008).

A 15-entry COCA batch contains forms of *seem* followed by *a lot to*, including “as a first-year festival seems a lot to ask of the public” (*Detroit News*, 2019) and “Doesn’t seem a lot to ask, does it?” (*The Sum of Us*, 1994). The batch also includes *to me*, so its total isn’t a count of infinitival complements.

The COCA List count for forms of *be a lot to* is 2,394 tokens. Saved examples include existential “There was a lot to do after Luke left” (*Southern Review*, 2019) and predicative “That was a lot to

take in” (*Dead to Me*, 2019) and “\$26 is a lot to pay for a ‘topping’” (*Atlanta Journal-Constitution*, 2014). All these batches were supplied by hand and remain unscreened; their totals aren’t counts of qualifying predicative uses. The record is under corpus/independent_argument/.

3.3 CONTEXTUAL RESTRICTION WITH ⟨few⟩

NOW: *Daily Times* (Pakistan), 20 October 2022; *New York Times*, 4 March 2022. Also “Everyone can have the ability to do this, but few have the durability to do it” (*Los Angeles Times*, 27 September 2021). Of 94 NOW lines for *few would*, read in full by Brett Reynolds, 82 have nothing in the visible context that supplies the set, 5 have it (“letting 1,000 flowers bloom and hoping a few would pan out”, *Computerworld*, 2021), and 7 can’t be decided from the window; the screening model had labelled 89 and 5, agreeing on four of the five. Lines and reading under corpus/independent_argument/.

3.4 EXTERNALLY DETERMINED ⟨few⟩

The lucky few is well attested as an independent argument with a relative: “Are you one of the lucky few who found powdered infant formula?” (*National Observer*, 3 October 2022); “is among the lucky few who already have that permanent freedom” (*Business Insider*, 11 February 2021); “Obialor is one of the lucky few who was able to reclaim the moment” (YNaïja, 11 September 2020); likewise “I am of the privileged few who can afford to take time off” (*The Guardian*, 1 September 2022). All from NOW, 17 September 2026; screened lines under corpus/independent_argument/.

REFERENCES

Huddleston, R., & Pullum, G. K. (2002). *The Cambridge grammar of the English language*. Cambridge University Press. <https://doi.org/10.1017/9781316423530>